

HOW TO VALIDATE A REAL PROBLEM

Executive guide to proving that a pain deserves priority before it gains solution, budget, and backlog space.

Includes an applied case, executive matrices, analytical frameworks, and an expanded sources page.

Author: Arthur do Amaral Anesclar do Valle

Signature: Artur Amaràl

1. Validation is not getting emotionally convinced

A real problem is not whatever sounds plausible or produces the strongest quote. It is what shows recurrence, cost, observable consequence, and enough weight to justify product attention. Validating pain means going beyond narrative and proving that it leaves traces in process, behavior, effort, or outcome. The point is not to reject the user's story. It is to discover whether that story describes structural friction or only episodic discomfort.

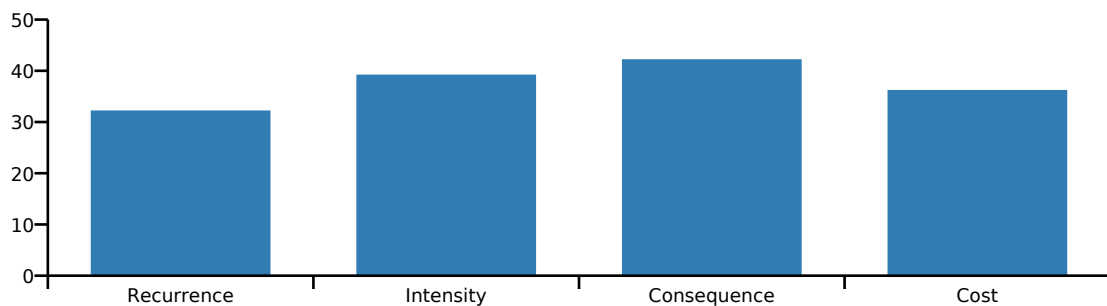
- Validated pain appears across more than one moment, profile, or context.
- A real problem usually produces loss, delay, workaround behavior, or repeated bad decisions.
- Without observable consequence, the team is facing a hypothesis that sounds strong but remains fragile.

2. The four criteria of problem validation

Validating a problem requires four complementary proofs: recurrence, intensity, consequence, and cost of ignoring it. If a pain appears only occasionally, carries low operational weight, or changes no meaningful behavior, it may exist, but it does not necessarily deserve roadmap space. Strong discovery prevents every friction from being promoted into priority.

Criterion	Validation question	What it proves
Recurrence	How often does this come back?	Pattern or exception
Intensity	How much does this really get in the way?	Pain weight
Consequence	What is lost when this happens?	Operational impact
Cost of ignoring	What worsens if nothing changes?	Real urgency

Relative decision weight of validation criteria



Decision weight

3. Where teams fail in validation

Teams fail when they validate too early, because they encounter a few positive signals and assume the pain is already proven. Another common mistake is relying only on interviews without checking whether the friction appears in real use, in metrics, or in cost perceived by more than one actor. The lower the methodological friction, the easier it becomes to elevate a weak problem into strategic priority.

Validation error	How it appears	Risk
Short sample	Two or three accounts become a pattern	Inflated priority
Only stated feedback	No behavior check	Overestimated pain
No cost read	The pain exists but carries little weight	Wasted roadmap space
No counter-proof	Nothing pressures the thesis	Fragile validation

4. How to validate with more rigor

The operating sequence is simple: formulate the pain, search for recurrence, estimate weight, observe consequence, and test the priority thesis. Not every validation requires a large experiment. Many require only enough discipline to avoid concluding too early. Validation is the act of filtering what deserves to advance, not merely finding something that sounds promising.

Step	Objective	Output
Formulation	Write the pain clearly	Explicit thesis
Repeatability check	Search for pattern	Comparable signal
Pain weight	Understand impact	Economic relevance
Priority test	Check whether it deserves roadmap movement	Stronger decision

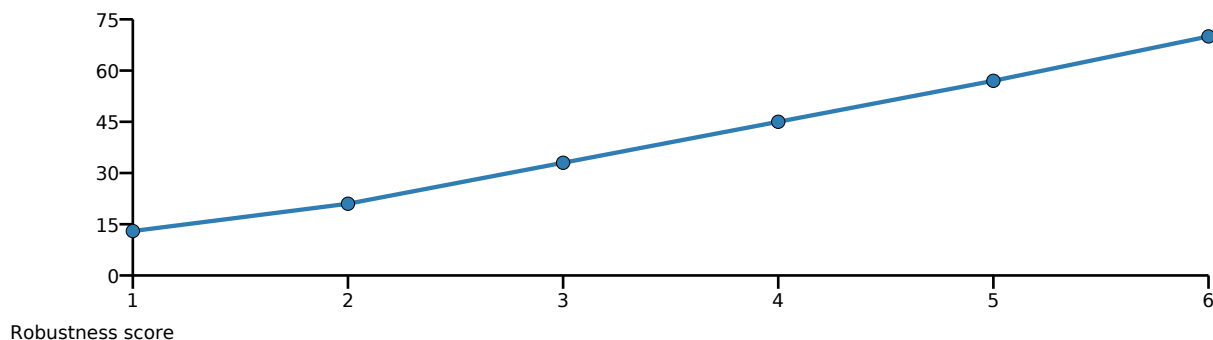
5. Artur Amaràl Vision

- Validating a real problem is an exercise in strategic coldness, not narrative enthusiasm.
- Mature teams do not ask only whether the pain exists. They ask whether it weighs enough to deserve the next major choice.
- Every strong validation carries a quiet companion question: what if we are overestimating this?

6. Expected result

When validation becomes more rigorous, fewer occasional pains gain protagonism, discard rates improve, and product investment becomes more consistent around what carries clear operational weight and meaningful return potential.

Projected evolution of validation robustness



Final insight: a real problem is not what moves the room the most in an interview. It is what still hurts when you try to measure it, compare it, and doubt it.

7. Sources and references

Conceptual base used to consolidate interviews, discovery, evidence triangulation, experimentation, and prioritization. The text in this PDF is authorial and interpretive; the references below serve as technical grounding and a path for deeper study.

- Nielsen Norman Group - when to use which UX research methods and how to avoid bad questioning.

<https://www.nngroup.com/articles/which-ux-research-methods/>

- Nielsen Norman Group - interview fundamentals and the limits of stated preference.

<https://www.nngroup.com/articles/user-interviews/>

- Product Talk - continuous discovery, assumption testing, and insight quality.

<https://www.producttalk.org/>

- Atlassian Jira Product Discovery - discovery, prioritization, and decision linkage.

<https://www.atlassian.com/software/jira/product-discovery>

- Amplitude - test signals, false-positive risk, and disciplined result reading.

<https://amplitude.com/explore/experiment/sequential-testing>

- Additional technical material on prioritization frameworks and observable evidence in product work.

<https://www.atlassian.com/software/jira/product-discovery/resources/handbook/prioritization>

Document prepared in recruiter-facing format, with a fictional numerical example, technical language, and deeper development without duplication.

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